

The 5 Checks I Run Before I Trust a Backup

A twenty-minute proficiency test for the computer your business lives on.

I spent ten years testing whether people were ready. This is the same test, smaller.

None of these five checks require you to buy anything, including from me. Run them on what you already have.

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WHERE THIS COMES FROM

For thirty-one years I was with the Salem Fire Department. The last ten of those I was Division Chief of Training. My job was not fires. My job was proficiency testing — finding out, in advance and on purpose, whether the people and the equipment could actually do the thing when it mattered.

Here is what that work teaches you, and it took me longer than it should have to apply it to my own desk:

Having equipment is not the standard. Demonstrating that it works is the standard.

That is what a drill is for. We did not run drills because we expected a fire on Tuesday. We ran them because you do not find out whether the plan works while the building is burning.

I run an internet business now, and everything it is worth sits on my computer. When I finally sat down and asked whether I could get it all back if the machine stopped tonight, the honest answer was that I did not know. I had assumed. That is not the same thing, and I of all people should have known better.

So I wrote down the checks. There are five. They take about twenty minutes.

Check 1. Restore one file. Right now.

The one almost nobody has ever run, and the one that decides whether you have a backup or a feeling.

Pick a file you would genuinely be upset to lose. Go to your backup — not the folder on your desktop, the actual backup — and bring that one file back. Open it. Confirm it is the current version and not a copy from eight months ago.

Why this is check number one. A backup nobody has restored from has never been tested, and every failure below is invisible until you try. Silent failures are ordinary: the drive mounted but stopped copying, the folder was never included, the subscription lapsed, the file is there but corrupt. Every one of those looks exactly like a working backup, right up until the morning you need it.

Pass: the file opened and it was current.

Fail, or “I’m not sure how to do that”: that is not an embarrassment, it is the finding. Nothing else on this list matters until this one passes.

Check 2. Where is the second copy, and is it somewhere the first one isn’t?

Two copies in one room is one copy.

The organising rule in this field is called **3–2–1**: three copies of anything you cannot lose, on two different kinds of storage, with one of them somewhere else entirely. It is not a vendor’s slogan — the U.S. Chamber of Commerce publishes a guide to it, which is how I first read about it.

The part people miss is the *somewhere else*. An external drive that lives on the same desk as the computer is not a second location. Theft takes the bag. A fire takes the room. A power surge takes both things plugged into the same strip. I spent thirty-one years watching what happens to everything inside a single room.

Ask: if the room your computer is in right now were emptied tonight, what would still exist, and where is it?

Check 3. Does it run without you remembering?

Find the date of the last completed run — not the day you set it up.

Anything that depends on a person remembering to do it will eventually go a month, and then a year. Backups that run on a schedule, on their own, without asking, are the only ones with a survival rate. The failure mode of a manual backup is not that you refuse. It is that you get busy.

Ask: what is the date on the last successful run, and would anything have told you if it had failed?

Check 4. Is your phone in it?

The device most likely to be lost or stolen is usually the one nobody included.

Almost every backup conversation is about the laptop. But the phone goes everywhere, it is the device most likely to be lost or stolen, and for a lot of people running something small it now holds the job-site photographs, the receipts, the client messages and the only copy of the number they wrote down in a parking lot.

Ask: if your phone went into a river this afternoon, what is on it that exists nowhere else?

Check 5. The first-morning list.

This one is a pre-incident plan. You walk the building before it burns.

Take five minutes and write down what you would need in the **first working morning** after losing everything. Not eventually. Tomorrow, to keep operating.

Most people's honest list is short and surprising — the customer list, the current job files, the tax folder, the passwords, the photographs of the work, one spreadsheet.

Then check that list against your backup, item by item. That comparison is the whole exercise, and it is the one that finds the gap. Backups tend to cover the obvious folder and miss the working files, the email and the accounting file.

Ask: is every item on my first-morning list actually inside the backup — and do I know that, or do I assume it?

WHEN YOU HAVE RUN ALL FIVE

If all five passed, you are in better shape than most people I talk to, and there is nothing here for you to do. That is the right outcome. A drill that everybody passes is still worth running, because now you know instead of assuming.

If one or more failed — that is the finding, and a finding is the entire point of a drill. You found out what does not work while it still does not matter. That is a good morning's work, not a bad one.

What I did after mine failed was go and look properly: at what I actually had, at what was actually available, and at the published prices, which I read myself rather than taking anybody's word for. I settled on a service called GotBackup and I am a member of it. You can read what I found, and where every number came from, on my page.

I am not going to tell you what is going to happen to you. I do not know, and I am suspicious of anybody who says they do. I will tell you what I check and why, and you can decide.

IF YOU GET STUCK

If you get stuck on any of the five — including on something you think is too basic to ask about — write to me and ask. I mean that. I spent ten years writing training for people who were not born knowing this either, and I have never once thought less of anybody for asking a plain question.

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